Two Systems

The service you describe, and the service that actually runs.

The wall · eight questions

1. When you can only map one journey, which one would you choose — and who loses because of it?
2. What conditions have to be true before you can start something? And what do you do when they are not?
3. Who do you leave out of a meeting or discussion, and what does that decision cost you later?
4. Two credible sources disagree. Which one do you believe, and what would change your mind?
5. Your design artefact or output is beautiful, but nobody acted on it or used it. What was actually missing?
6. The person who is most senior or most authoritative in the room is wrong. What would you do?
7. What would you have to measure for a CFO to fund your idea or vision, and what would you refuse to measure?
8. The AI model produced results in four minutes. What in your work is still yours?

In the room: all eight questions are printed and posted on the physical wall.

Opening action: Choose one question in 30 seconds. Then write an answer on an A5 card, sign it, and pin it — five silent minutes, no discussion. There is no allocation. In S13, you will reopen the card and answer again.

Studio · The Honest Map · 75 min

1 · The Clean Process Line · 12 min

Mode: individual → pairs · devices away

Prompt: Map what the university's portal, emails, and official instructions told you was supposed to happen for enrolment and add/drop.

Output: A clean process line

Materials: Colour 1 stickies · Sharpie · wall space

1. Colour 1: one sticky per step, in the order the documentation described it.

2 · The Real Trail · 15 min

Mode: pairs · devices away

Prompt: Now think back to what you actually did — not what the portal said. What did you actually type, send, ask, or search? Was there a WhatsApp group, a friend you texted, a walk to the office?

Output: The two-colour gap

Materials: Colour 2 stickies · Colour 1 map · Sharpie

1. Colour 2: place beside the Colour 1 step where your real experience differed. Beside, never on top.
2. The space between Colour 1 and Colour 2 is the artefact — that gap is what you're here to study.

3 · Name the Pattern · 15 min

Mode: tables of 6 · devices away

Prompt: Around the table, one sentence each: 'I thought ___, but what actually happened was ___.' Once everyone written, go to step 2 & 3.

Output: Shared pattern sheet

Materials: A3 sheet · existing two-colour maps · Sharpie

1. Each person: one sentence using the "I thought ___ / actually happened ___" template.
2. Table listens for repeats across different people's stories.
3. Cluster similar sentences, write the 3 clearest shared patterns on A3.

4 · Locate the Divergence · 18 min

Mode: tables · devices away

Prompt: Sort the existing gap map into three labelled zones and discuss divergence.

Output: A layered gap map

Materials: existing two-colour gap map · frontstage / backstage / enabling labels · Sharpie

1. Take the Colour 2 gaps from Round 2.
2. Sort each into Frontstage / Backstage / Enabling.
3. As a table, agree which zone holds the most divergence.

5 · The Real Design · 15 min

Mode: tables · devices away

Prompt: Rewrite the intent in one page — not what the organisation documented or assumed, but what it actually is, based on everything you just mapped.

Output: One line, posted

Materials: paper for one posted line · two-colour gap map · Sharpie

1. As a table, look back across your pattern sheet and layered gap map.
2. Agree on one sentence completing "This service's real design is ___."
3. Write it on one line, sign as a table, post to the wall.

Methods

canonical method

Service blueprint

A service blueprint is a diagram of service delivery. Roles sit on a vertical axis and delivery steps sit on a horizontal axis, so the map can show each role's actions and the relationships between them.

Begin with an existing service, or a well-defined concept, rather than using the blueprint to generate ideas. Set the stages across the map, list the roles down the side, and map each role's action at every relevant stage.

Draw the line of visibility. Place work a user can see above that line and back-office work below it. Then read across the map for hand-offs and cross-functional relationships between frontstage and backstage processes.

1. Start with an existing service. Do not begin with an idea.
2. Put delivery stages across the map.
3. List every role involved down the side.
4. Map each role's action at each stage.
5. Draw the line of visibility.
6. Put user-seen work above the line.
7. Put back-office work below the line.
8. Read the hand-offs between roles.

> **Common failure.** Using the blueprint as an ideation tool rather than to analyse an existing service or specify a well-defined concept.

Service Design Tools — Service Blueprint

studio adaptation

Two-colour divergence mapping

Adapted from: Service blueprinting

1. Colour 1 maps what is supposed to happen, one step per sticky. Colour 2 records what someone would find if they followed the real trail.

2. Place Colour 2 beside Colour 1, never on top of it. The space between the colours is the artefact.

Keep the documented line and the lived trail legible at the same time. Do not correct the first account with the second; the divergence between them is the evidence this studio adaptation is designed to preserve.

1. Colour 1: map what is supposed to happen. One step per sticky.
2. Colour 2: ask what someone would find if they followed the real trail.
3. Place Colour 2 beside Colour 1. Never on top of it.
4. The space between the colours is the artefact.

> **Common failure.** Replacing Colour 1 instead of sitting beside it. You lose the gap, which was the whole point.

Background — Service Design Tools, Service Blueprint

Assessment · Frame · Decide · Prove

Frame · Decide · Prove is used twice: once on the team project and once on yourself via weekly reflections. The split is **60% team project · 40% individual Logbook**.

Band	The test
Distinction	Holds under challenge. Asked “why?” at any point, you answer with evidence — and can name what would have changed your mind.
Proficient	Holds, but breaks at one or two points. Reasoning present, partly assumed.
Developing	Asserted rather than shown. The steps are there; they are not connected.
Not yet	Steps missing, or the chain runs backwards — solution first, evidence retrofitted.

The logbook

Handwrite one A5 card at the end of every session. Photograph it and upload it to the PolyU LMS before the next session. Thirteen entries build the individual report a little each week. The LMS timestamp is the record of truth.

AI

Use it, and use it openly. How much you use it is never assessed. Only your reasoning about it is.

The live briefs

Real Hong Kong organisations. Brief providers join the 12 October panel. The panel questions and advises. Michael marks.

Reflection I

1. What did we decide — and what did we decide *against*?
2. What was the reasoning? Not the outcome. The reasoning.
3. What would have changed my mind?

Reflection II

1. What do I think differently now than I did at 09:30?
2. What did I do or say today that I would do differently?
3. What can I still not answer?

Then: one line, signed, for the wall.

S01 wall line: One thing I now know I do not know.

References

- Service Design Tools · Service blueprint
- Shostack (1982) · How to Design a Service
- European Journal of Marketing record · How to Design a Service
- Buchanan (1992) · Wicked Problems in Design Thinking
- Nielsen Norman Group · Service Design 101
- Harvard Business Review · Designing Services That Deliver

Bring to S02

- One real brief you have been given — a project brief, a job description, a client email, an assignment. Anything where somebody asked you to do something. We are going to take one apart.
- One sentence: a service that failed you this year.
- A pen you actually like. You will be handwriting a card at the end of every session for six weeks.

On Friday you receive project briefs — Hong Kong enterprises have given us real problems they have not solved.